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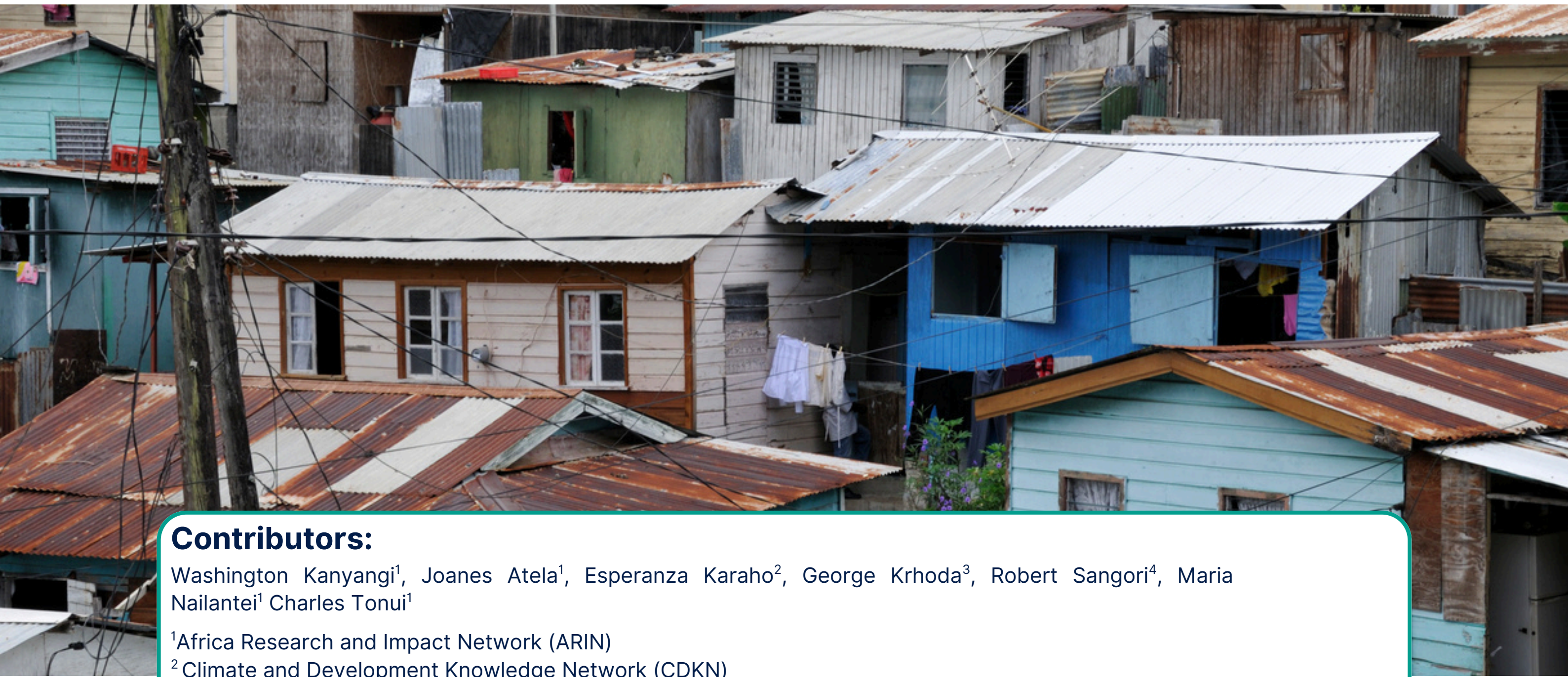
REPUBLIC OF KENYA

POLICY BRIEF | NO 26

BRIDGING EVIDENCE GAPS TO BUILD CLIMATE RESILIENCE WITH THE URBAN POOR (BCRUP) PROGRAMME: THE AFRICAN CONTEXT.



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Summary

Africa's rapid urbanisation is intensifying climate vulnerabilities in informal settlements located in fragile ecosystems. By 2050, nearly two-thirds of Africans will live in cities. Fragmented data, financing gaps, weak policies, and limited metrics hinder effective resilience investments.

This brief, drawn from the African Urban Forum II side event, proposes solutions across four themes: evidence and knowledge systems, innovative financing, science-to-policy interfaces, and evaluation metrics. It highlights Kenya's co-created digital Monitoring, Evaluation, Reporting and Learning (MERL) Tool as a practical model for closing evidence gaps.

Key Messages

1. Africa must establish an interoperable African Resilience Data Facility hosted by the African Union to centralise and standardise data from local to continental levels, supporting the development of bankable project pipelines.
2. An integrated, risk-informed blended financing framework grounded in robust data and de-risking tools (e.g., climate risk insurance) can unlock dormant domestic capital for resilience infrastructure in underserved neighbourhoods.
3. Co-created policy and regulatory frameworks with urban poor communities are essential to guide non-maladaptive investments, boost investor confidence, and advance climate justice.
4. A harmonized urban climate resilience indicator framework, supported by digital tools like Kenya's MERL Tool, is critical for evaluating effectiveness, enabling learning, and informing future action.

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Background

Africa is experiencing unprecedented urbanisation, with thousands of urban settings emerging across various terrains, notably in fragile ecosystems such as along rivers, the shores of lakes and oceans, wetland encroachment, hilly and mountainous areas, and valleys, among others. By 2050, approximately two-thirds of the continent's population is projected to live in cities (AfDB, 2023). This will be accompanied by the intractable challenges, such as the impact of climate change, poverty, and pandemics. Further, this will push the majority living below the poverty line to reside in fragile ecosystems. The population influx in the cities, coupled with climate change, poverty, and pandemics, has disproportionately affected the urban poor in informal settlements.

These settlements often house a large share of the city's population on a tiny fraction of land. Presently in Kenya, 60% of urban families live in informal settlements due to inadequate economic status. Like other African cities, Nairobi experiences an unsustainable rate of urbanisation, leading to population congestion, especially in informal settlements, and exerting pressure on existing infrastructures. To put this into perspective, there are an estimated 158 informal settlements with almost 70% of the total Nairobi county's population, occupying 5% of the total area. For instance, in the Kibra informal settlement, approximately 22,000 residents live along the Ngong River, which often floods during the March, April and May rainy season. Interventions administered over the decades have always been in the form of reactive emergency response rather than proactive and strategic responses to foreseen as well as unforeseen potential hazards. Owing to such inefficiencies in the approaches leveraged for mitigating the impacts of disasters in African cities, 83% of the cities remain highly vulnerable to climate risks.

Evidently, African informal settlements were disproportionately impacted by the coronavirus (COVID-19) pandemic, revealing and exacerbating the already embedded climate vulnerabilities among the urban poor. These challenges call for re-thinking Africa's present and future urban systems that will not only be able to absorb pressures from the fast-growing population in informal settlements but also be climate resilient against the more frequent and severe climate risks, including flooding, heat waves and pandemics.

In response to these challenges, the United Nations launched the Building Climate Resilience with the Urban Poor (BCRUP) programme, co-led by Kenya and Brazil in 2019 as a global climate action initiative with the aim of addressing acute climate vulnerabilities of the urban poor, particularly in the Global South. BCRUP has been positioned to contribute to the implementation and realisation of the Global Championship on the Right to Adequate Housing, which was recently unveiled at the 80th Session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA). Therefore, BCRUP is widely recognised at the global level as a flagship initiative that aims to strengthen the adaptive capacity of the urban poor in low-income neighborhoods, thus enabling them to withstand and recover from climate-induced shocks and stresses while also aligning itself with respective national development priorities.

Introduction

Since its inception, the BCRUP programme has received support from most African governments, including Kenya as the host and steering entity. Technical support from BCRUP partners, such as the Kenyan Government, Africa Research and Impact Network (ARIN), the African Union (AU), UNECA, the Africa Green Climate Funds National Designated Authorities Network (AfDAN), the United Cities and Local Governments of Africa (UCLG Africa), UN-Habitat, Commonwealth Secretariat and Habitat for Humanity, has led to its key milestones, including; the launch of BCRUP implementation strategy by Kenya's Head of State in 2023 and its recognition at the African Ministerial Conference on the Environment.

As illustrated in Figure 1 below, BCRUP has six (6) key outcome areas, including: Hotspot identification and Mapping of vulnerable urban Poor Neighbourhoods, Green Climate Resilience Urban Spatial Plans, Resilient Urban Basic Services including Human Settlement and Infrastructure Improvement, Green Urban Economy, community adaptation, livelihood strategies and tenure security interventions, Strengthened Nationally Determined Contributions, and Governance Framework. The realisation of the outcome areas hinges greatly on locally-led evidence and citizen science to inform its program activities, as well as investments.

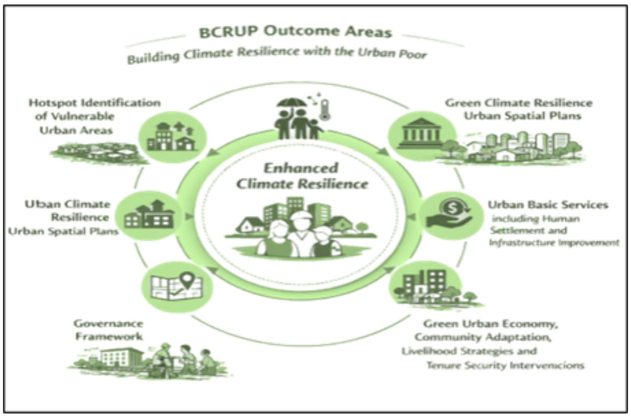

Figure 1: BCRUP Outcome areas.

This policy brief synthesises insights from the African Urban Forum II side event *'Bridging Evidence Gaps to Build Climate Resilience with the Urban Poor (BCRUP) Programme: The African Context'* as well as other interlinked side events. It distils key discussions into four (4) thematic areas, namely: interrogating the evidence and knowledge ecosystem, exploring innovative financing instruments for building climate resilience in Africa's cities, strengthening the science-to-policy interface in building climate resilience with the urban poor, and developing robust metrics and indicators for evaluating urban climate resilience outcomes.

Key Findings

A. Interrogating the evidence and knowledge ecosystem

1. Africa holds rich multi-scale data from censuses, meteorological services, land-use plans, and community sources, but datasets are fragmented and lack interoperability, limiting holistic risk understanding and nexus approaches.

2. Co-production with urban poor communities through participatory flood mapping, hotspot identification, risk and vulnerability assessment with resilient urban poor neighbourhoods action plans, and lived-experience data builds credible, context-specific knowledge and ownership.

3. Standardising metrics and key terms enables interoperability and effective monitoring, evaluation, reporting and learning.

4. Private-sector actors, such as development finance institutions (DFIs) and pension funds, have a unique opportunity to catalyse the generation of contextualised evidence, as they can introduce conditionalities, such as requiring contextualised data, prior to investment decisions. In collaboration with key stakeholder groups, they can invest in scaling open data infrastructures/platforms that are easily interoperable and accessible across systems and to relevant stakeholders. The established evidence ecosystem can be leveraged to inform their risk appetite for climate investments in vulnerable urban settings.

5. There is limited capacity and competence among policymakers and community members to interpret and utilise climate and socio-economic data that is central to informing suitable interventions for enhancing climate resilience in vulnerable urban areas. This underscores the need to establish periodic training programmes in data analytics, climate risk assessment and evidence-based decision-making for capacity building. A memorandum of understanding (MoU) for data sharing between the private sector and state departments is also essential to ensure that data protection laws in respective African countries are upheld.

B. Innovative financing instruments for building climate resilience with Africa's urban Poor

1. Africa has substantial domestic capital, including treasury and foreign sovereign bonds. However, a significant portion of this capital is dormant and risk-averse. This stems from limited pathways for de-risking investments and evidence gaps on the bankability of proposed climate-resilience investments. Further, current public climate investment frameworks tend to rely on historical data sets and conventional risk assumptions that are not updated with climate risk assessment data containing current and future projections for informal urban settings. As such, these evidence gaps are known to undermine investor confidence, as they are unable to assess the viability of climate investments in vulnerable urban neighbourhoods.

2. Blended financing options for sustainable urban development, particularly in informal settlements, have proven effective in attracting both private and concessional capital for climate resilience infrastructure. In this context, grants can be utilised for de-risking components of the climate ventures that are considered high-risk by absorbing the first losses, thus increasing investor confidence. Thereafter, private capital from DFIs can be leveraged for scaling these investments for sustainable socio-economic benefits for the urban poor.

3. Community-driven financing pathways, especially through savings, credit cooperatives and microfinance institutions, can play a significant role in mobilising social capital for the development of small-scale infrastructure such as constructing and maintaining drainage systems and establishing clean water points and communal sanitation facilities.

4. There is a need to resolve and formalise land tenure insecurities in informal settlements, as it is critical for unlocking climate resilience investments, especially from private sector actors. More often than not, unclear landownership logs in urban settings often deter long-term investments. Insecure land tenure systems often inhibit collective community buy-in into climate resilience investments for fear of future disenfranchisement.

5. Proactive investment partnership conversations between government statement departments and private capital custodians, such as pension funders, wealth management firms and insurance companies, could provide alternative avenues for designing interventions that meet some of the private sector conditionalities. This may include: integration of business models with clear cash flow frameworks and attractive return on investments (ROI), socio-economic indicators on the impacts and transparent risk sharing mechanisms. Clarity on the scope of government incentives, such as risk guarantees, tax incentives, etc., will be fundamental in building trust.

6. African governments with robust technical institutional capacity gaps in monitoring, reporting, and verification (MRV) systems for tracking climate finance and their impacts tend to access more domestic and foreign private capital. MRV systems are essential in measuring climate action outcomes against the climate finance flows. Such systems correlate directly with investor confidence as they demonstrate impact that is critical for results-based and performance-linked financing streams. Therefore, strong MRV, as enabled by digital tools like Monitoring, Evaluation, Reporting, and Learning (MERL), builds investor confidence.

C. Fortifying the science-to-policy interface for urban resilience

1. The efficiency and effectiveness of urban climate resilience interventions often depend on coherent policy frameworks that aim to ground and align institutional mandates for executing and coordinating long-term climate resilience investments with the urban poor. This is critical for mitigating fragmentation and duplication of climate actions.

2. Coherent policy and regulatory frameworks and participatory co-creation with urban poor communities are needed. Clear policy frameworks are central to establishing regulatory frameworks, such as physical and land use planning guides, that can inform non-maladaptive urban climate investment designs, which do not transfer risk to other neighbourhoods within the city. As such, strong and coherent regulatory frameworks within urban jurisdictions tend to enhance investor confidence, especially among private-sector investors. This will create an enabling environment for public-private partnerships (PPPs) and blended climate financing options that aim to scale and sustain risk-informed urban development against climate risks.

3. Participatory approaches in co-production or review of land use policies in urban jurisdictions are essential for amplifying the voices of the urban poor. This will ensure that climate-resilient urban development investments integrate climate justice in interventions, thus protecting the dignity of vulnerable and marginalised groups. Similarly, researchers who actively engage policymakers and the urban poor in evidence generation processes often get their evidence-based recommendations incorporated within national and local policy instruments.

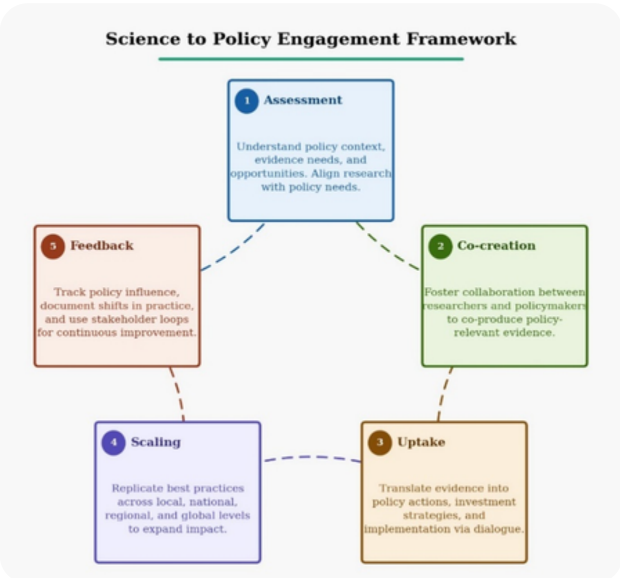

Figure 2: Science to Policy Engagement Framework

D. Developing indicators to evaluate the impact of urban climate resilience investments

1. African governments have been struggling to establish frameworks that would measure the impacts of urban climate investments. These investments are known to be multi-dimensional including; physical infrastructure, socio-economic dynamics, and capacity building. Evidence on these multi-dimensional investments on what is working and what is not is critical in informing future climate investment options. Fundamentally, tracking of these investment impacts often reveals whether adaptation capacities of the intended beneficiaries have been enhanced, it exposes the existing disparities and allows for proven interventions to be scaled.

2. Multi-dimensional tracking of climate adaptation interventions in the urban communities using input, process, output, outcome, and impact indicators (OECD, 2018) is critical. This includes input indicators (resources invested, financial instruments, sources of funding), process indicators (enablers), output indicators (tangible and immediate deliverables), outcome indicators (medium-term impacts, e.g., reduced magnitude of flood disasters), and impact indicators (long-term impacts of the interventions, e.g., improved livelihoods, resilient urban communities). Kenya's MERL Tool provides a practical, scalable model with real-time equity-focused tracking, community hotspot mapping, and learning loops.

3. Integration of these indicators into national and local policy instruments after alignment and standardisation is essential in enabling comparative analysis of the outputs and outcomes of urban climate resilience investments across African countries. As such, evidence from the analysis process may be used to inform continental knowledge sharing convenings, policy reviews and investment decision-making (determining priority intervention areas and budgeting) in vulnerable urban settings. Consequently, this process has the potential to enhance accountability among state departments and coordination across the ministerial sectors. Results from the indicator framework can effectively inform evidence-based assessment periodic reports on the status of Africa's urban climate resilience.

Figure 3: Urban Resilience Indicator Framework

Recommendations

1. **T**he African Union Commission, with Regional Economic Communities, should establish an interoperable African Resilience Data Facility. Operational efficiencies will lie in the effective consolidation processes of respective country datasets, and rolling out periodic capacity building programmes on data analysis, modelling and visualisation among stakeholders. Fundamentally, the capacity-building program will ensure data quality to enable interoperability and orient users on data protocols. The success of the African Resilience Data Facility will be critical in supporting knowledge sharing across African nations and their development partners, as well as objectively informing regional funding for urban resilience.

2. African governments, DFIs, and private sector actors should co-develop an integrated, risk-informed blended financing framework with strong MRV. The integrated framework will create an enabling ecosystem that has the potential to unlock dormant domestic capital that can be utilised for climate risk infrastructure investment. As such, the framework should be grounded by interoperable data systems to inform different forms of climate interventions across economic sectors in vulnerable urban neighbourhoods, while incorporating feasible climate financing options, such as de-risking financial instruments and climate risk insurance.

3. National and local governments, with researchers and urban poor communities, should institutionalise participatory co-creation in the formulation or review of policy and regulatory frameworks meant to guide climate-resilient urban investments. This will mitigate against maladaptive interventions, ensure interventions respond to the unique adaptation needs of the urban poor, and promote knowledge sharing among partners.

4. The African Union and partners should lead a locally-led and harmonised indicator framework, building on OECD categories to strengthen evidence-based decision-making on what's working and what's not, promote intersectoral coordination, and inform knowledge-sharing convenings.

Conclusion

Bridging evidence gaps is fundamental to realising Agenda 2063's vision of inclusive, sustainable urban development. By investing in interoperable data systems, blended financing, participatory policies, and digital MERL tools, Africa can turn evidence into actionable resilience that prioritises the urban poor. This iterative feedback loop is essential for continuous learning, adaptive management, and improved decision-making in rapidly changing urban environments. To this end, the future of Africa's cities will be defined not by the data we generate, but by the extent to which that data is deliberately connected to the lived realities of the urban poor, translated into relevant policies, and made fit for purpose.

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